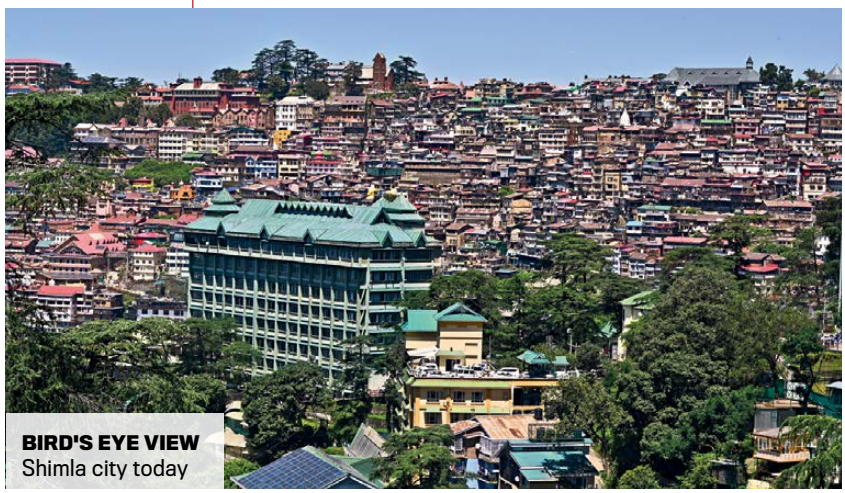


BIRD'S EYE VIEW
Shimla city today

Authority of India) chairman Santosh Yadav. Gadkari's ministry has already cleared Rs 400 crore under the Central Road and Infrastructure Fund (CRIF) for repair and restoration works.

RUMBLING MOUNTAINS

A recent report of the Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change (IPCC) had pointed to an increase in incidents in extreme events in the Himalayan region as well as coastal areas. In Himachal, though several studies have been undertaken to assess the carrying capacity of hill towns like Shimla, Manali, McLeodganj and Kasauli, there has hardly been any enforcement of the recommendations to regulate the haphazard construction activity. Meanwhile, the Bhupender Yadav-led Union environment, forest and climate change ministry has proposed forming a 13-member technical committee to evaluate the "carrying capacity" of all 13 Himalayan states.

Experts like former director of the Geological Survey of India Om Bhargava explain that the near-vertical cutting (of the mountains) has destabilised the slopes. "It does not matter if there is rain or not. Sooner or later, the slopes will want to acquire equilibrium and slide downwards," he points out.

BACK TO THE FUTURE

Both environmentalists and the National Green Tribunal have raised concerns about the Shimla Master Plan, 2041 (SMP-41). The former has moved the apex court saying it will not decongest the city and is ecologically unsustainable

- The SMP-41 etimates that the Shimla area's population will hit 650,000 by 2041, including a floating population of 130,000
- 22,450 ha. included in the development plan. This includes Shimla city, special area development authorities of Kufri, Shoghi and Ghanahatti Special Area, additional Shimla planning area, and a few villages
- Developing Jubbarhatti and Ghandal as activity-based 'counter-magnet' towns with provision for urban amenities such as educational institutions, hospitals and markets
- Satellite townships to be developed in Ghandal, Fagu, Naldehra and Chamiyana area near the four-lane bypass to decongest the core area
- SMP-41 paves the way for construction in 17 green belts with certain restrictions and also in the core area where construction activity was recently banned by the NGT
- Decongesting the habitats at Kasumpti, Sanjauli, Chakker, Summer Hill, Totu, Longwood and Bharari, by shifting some commercial activities to the periphery of the city

Vertical cutting means the slope of the mountain gets very close to 90 degrees, whereas geologists insist the slope should be less than 60 degrees. They also say soil in the mountains needs at least six years to settle after the cutting. This year, because of the continuous rains and then spells of heavy showers, the slopes along the highways have been sending down boulders, causing traffic disruptions at regular intervals. Sukhu points out that landslides are part of the nature of the hills, but emphasises that more tunnels were needed (see interview *'The floods must be declared a national calamity'*). Now that the NHAI is clearing the debris, it's his job to get areas denotified for its disposal. For this, he will have to work with the MoEFCC.

The IPCC report also warns that the Himalayas are poised to experience a shift in rainfall patterns. Sukhu says they are aware of the challenges faced by Shimla and are working out plans to conduct studies of load-bearing capacities. He, too, puts the blame on climate change. "Even our cold deserts saw heavy rainfall, there were cloudbursts, the continuous rains led to land- and mudslides even in the remotest of the areas. So it's unfair to blame it all on urbanisation alone. There are issues, we are studying them and will take corrective measures. But the bigger culprit is the change in weather patterns," he says.

The chief minister does not agree that Shimla cannot have multi-storey buildings, as red-flagged by several experts. Instead, he says, Shimla needs better structural engineering for the buildings and better understanding of the soil's load-bearing capacity. Environmentalists, however, believe that Shimla and the developmental strategies for the Himalayan region should prioritise climate resilience instead of solely pursuing infrastructure expansion. Unfortunately, the time for discussion is already past. Shimla, if it is to be saved, needs immediate action on the ground. ■